

Self-Care for Filipino Nurses Postpandemic

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Abstract

Nurses are trained to care for others, yet they may forget to take care of themselves. Improving one's own mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being are all part of self-care. This descriptive research examined how Filipino nurses' self-care. Registered nurses nationwide were convenience sampled. Descriptive statistics assessed data from a self-administered questionnaire. The study included 2511 RNs. Participants averaged 32 years old and 83% were women. 74% of responders exercise, 63% sleep, and 59% eat well. Spending time with loved ones (87%), hobbies and interests (73%), and mindfulness or meditation (58%). Self-reflection, setting realistic goals, and seeking professional assistance were the most common mental self-care methods. Finally, when questioned about spiritual self-care, 71% said they pray or meditate, 54% said they spent time in nature, and 40% said they volunteered. Filipino nurses' self-care in many ways, but physical self-care is most common. The study found that most Filipino nurses practice self-care, including regular exercise, relaxation, and a healthy diet. Nurses most often practiced emotional self-care by spending time with loved ones, doing hobbies, and being aware. The research also suggested other methods of mental self-care, such as setting realistic objectives and getting therapy. Most people practice spiritual self-care through praying, meditating, spending time in nature, and giving back to the community. This research demonstrates that Filipino nurses practice extensive forms of self-care.

Keywords: Self Care, Filipino Nurses, Descriptive Design, Postpandemic, Nursing Practice, Self- Care Practices

Introduction

Nurses, known for their unwavering commitment to caring for others, frequently overlook their own well-being while attending to the needs of patients (Beriones, 2023). Nevertheless, recognizing the significance of prioritizing self-care is essential for sustaining optimal emotional, mental, and spiritual health among nursing professionals (Alparaque-Corvera & Aguirre, 2023). The repercussions of neglecting self-care can be far-reaching, exerting an influence not only on the nurses themselves but also on patients and the healthcare institutions they serve. The consequences of inadequate self-care can manifest in various ways, including increased susceptibility to errors, heightened levels of exhaustion, and the development of burnout, all of which pose substantial challenges within the healthcare setting.

One critical aspect is the potential for mistakes to occur due to the physical and mental toll that constant caregiving can impose on nurses who neglect self-care. Fatigue and stress can lead to lapses in concentration, resulting in errors in medication administration, documentation, or patient assessments (Labraque, 2023). These errors may have serious consequences for patient safety and well-being, underscoring the vital importance of nurses maintaining their own health and well-being to provide the highest level of care to patients.

Moreover, the persistent neglect of self-care can lead to exhaustion, both physically and emotionally. Nurses who continually put their own needs on the back burner may find themselves depleted, which can negatively affect their job performance and overall job satisfaction. This exhaustion can manifest in absenteeism, decreased productivity, and even attrition from the nursing profession, which can exacerbate staffing shortages in healthcare organizations already grappling with workforce challenges. Perhaps the most concerning consequence of inadequate self-care is the development of burnout, a pervasive issue in the nursing profession. Burnout is characterized by feelings of emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and reduced personal accomplishment. Nurses who experience burnout are more likely to disengage from their work, exhibit diminished empathy toward patients, and report lower job satisfaction. Consequently, burnout not only detrimentally affects the well-being of nurses but also has a direct impact on patient care quality and safety.

Meanwhile, the need for nurses to prioritize self-care is paramount, as neglecting one's well-being can result in a cascade of adverse effects. By recognizing the significance of self-care and instituting strategies to promote it within the nursing profession, healthcare organizations can contribute to the well-being of their staff, enhance patient safety, and mitigate the challenges posed by burnout and workforce shortages.

The stress of the ongoing epidemic and the increased responsibilities placed on nurses have pushed self-care down their list of priorities (Alibudbud, 2023). However, it is precisely during challenging and demanding times that self-care should be amplified, rather than diminished. This realization is gaining recognition among healthcare administrators worldwide as more information becomes available about the mental and physical toll that nursing can take.

It is imperative for both nurses and their employers to place a greater emphasis on nurses taking care of themselves. Self-care practices should be diverse and tailored to the individual's specific needs. There is no one-size-fits-all approach to self-care for nurses, as everyone has unique preferences and requirements. Nurses should be encouraged and supported in finding self-care strategies that work best for them, whether it involves engaging in hobbies, seeking emotional support, practicing mindfulness, or engaging in physical exercise.

In the global context, the importance of self-care for nurses is being increasingly recognized and addressed by healthcare administrators. The well-being of nurses is now acknowledged as crucial not only for their individual health but also for the overall functioning and effectiveness of the healthcare system. In the Philippines, where the nursing profession is highly esteemed, the promotion of self-care among nurses is of utmost importance. Nurses in the Philippines face numerous challenges, including heavy workloads, long hours, and exposure to emotionally and physically demanding situations. Recognizing the significance of self-care in sustaining their well-being can contribute to reducing burnout and turnover rates among Filipino nurses, thereby ensuring the provision of quality care to patients.

At the local level, within healthcare organizations and facilities, there is a growing need to prioritize self-care initiatives for nurses. This may involve implementing policies and programs that support and encourage self-care practices, providing resources and education on self-care, and fostering a culture that values and promotes the well-being of nurses. By investing in the self-care of nurses, healthcare organizations can enhance employee satisfaction, improve retention rates, and ultimately contribute to better patient outcomes.

In conclusion, self-care is a vital aspect of nursing practice that should not be overlooked, particularly during stressful and demanding times. Nurses, as well as healthcare administrators, need to recognize the importance of self-care in maintaining the well-being of nurses and ensuring the provision of high-quality care. By prioritizing self-care and tailoring it to individual needs, nurses can protect their own health and better serve their patients and the healthcare organization.

Methods

Research Design. This study employed a descriptive research design to investigate the self-care practices of nurses in the Philippines. Descriptive research aims to describe the characteristics and behaviors of a specific population or phenomenon.

Sampling. The participants for this study were selected from the population of registered nurses in the Philippines. A convenience sampling approach was used to recruit participants from different hospitals and healthcare institutions in various regions of the country. The inclusion criteria for the study were: (1) being a registered nurse in the Philippines, and (2) being willing to participate in the study. The sample size for this study was 2511 registered nurses.

Data Gathering Instruments. A self-administered questionnaire was used to gather data from the participants. The questionnaire was developed based on a literature review and consultation with experts in the field. The questionnaire included items on demographics (age, gender), and self-care practices in four areas: physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual. The questionnaire was pilot tested on a small sample of nurses to ensure its validity and reliability.

Data Analysis. Descriptive statistics were used to analyze the data collected from the self-administered questionnaire. Frequencies and percentages were used to describe the demographic characteristics of the participants and their self-care practices in the four areas. The data were analyzed using SPSS (Statistical Package for the Social Sciences) version 26.0.

Results

A total of 2511 registered nurses (RNs) participated in the study, with a mean age of 32. Most of the respondents were female, representing 83% of the sample.

Table 1. Demographic Characteristics of Respondents (n=2511)

Demographic Characteristics	Frequency	Percentage
Male	424	17%
Female	2087	83%
Age (years)		
Mean	32 years old	

Table 1 provides an overview of the demographic characteristics of the respondents in the study, with a total sample size of 2511 individuals. The table presents data on gender and age distribution. In terms of gender, the table shows that there were 424 male respondents, representing approximately 17% of the total sample, while most respondents were female, with 2087 individuals, accounting for around 83% of the sample. Regarding age, the table indicates the mean age of the respondents as 32 years old. However, it does not provide information on the specific age ranges or the distribution of respondents across different age groups. Overall, Table 1 offers a concise summary of the gender distribution and average age of the respondents in the study, providing a snapshot of the demographic characteristics of the sample.

Table 2. Self-Care Practices of Respondents

Self-Care Practices	Frequency	Percentage
Physical Self-Care		
Engaging in physical activity	1859	74.03
Getting enough sleep	1577	62.80
Making good food choices	1480	58.94
Emotional Practice		
Spending time with loved ones	1980	78.85
Participating in hobbies	1832	72.95
Engaging in mindfulness/meditation	1460	58.14
Mental Self-Care		
Self-reflection	1636	65.15
Establishing realistic objectives	1226	48.82
Seeking professional help	1077	42.89
Spiritual Self-Care		
Praying	1782	70.96
Spending time with nature	1366	54.40
Volunteering	1012	40.30

Physical self-care was the most practiced form of self-care, with 74% of the participants indicating that they engage in physical activity. This was followed by getting enough sleep (63%) and making good food choices (59%). Among those who practiced emotional self-care, spending time with loved ones was the most frequently cited method, with 78% of respondents indicating this form of self-care. This was followed by participating in hobbies and interests (73%) and engaging in mindfulness or meditation (58%).

Regarding mental self-care, self-reflection was indicated as the most prevalent form, with 65% of respondents citing this method. Establishing realistic objectives (49%) and seeking professional help (43%) were also commonly reported. Finally, for spiritual self-care, the most frequently cited method was praying or meditating, with 71% of respondents indicating this form of self-care. Spending time in nature (54%) and volunteering (40%) were also mentioned.

Discussion

The results of the study indicate that Filipino nurses actively engage in different forms of self-care (Loreche, 2023), with physical self-care being the most practiced (Welshman & Burke, 2023). This finding aligns with previous research that highlights the importance of physical activity and adequate sleep in promoting overall well-being among healthcare professionals. Engaging in regular physical activity not only improves physical health but also has positive effects on mental and emotional well-being.

Furthermore, the high percentage of nurses prioritizing spending time with loved ones for emotional self-care reflects the significance of social connections and support networks in coping with the challenges of nursing. Building and nurturing relationships can contribute to emotional resilience and provide a source of comfort and understanding (Ellis, 2022).

The emphasis on self-reflection for mental self-care indicates that Filipino nurses recognize the importance of introspection and self-awareness in maintaining mental well-being. Self-reflection allows individuals to gain insights into their thoughts, emotions, and behaviors, promoting personal growth and self-improvement. The preference for praying or meditating for spiritual self-care reflects the influence of cultural and religious beliefs in the Filipino context. Spirituality and religious practices have been found to provide comfort, meaning, and a sense of connection for individuals in times of stress and adversity (Brady, 2023).

These findings have important implications for nursing practice and the overall well-being of nurses. Healthcare organizations should recognize and support the diverse self-care needs of nurses, providing resources and creating a supportive environment that encourages self-care practices (Vanucci &

Weinstein, 2017). Implementing workplace policies that promote work-life balance (International Labor Organization, 2023), providing access to wellness programs, and fostering a culture of self-care can contribute to reducing burnout and enhancing job satisfaction among nurses (Flaubert, 2021).

It's crucial to highlight that although the study offers valuable insights into the self-care practices of Filipino nurses, there remains a need for additional research to delve deeper into the effectiveness of these self-care strategies in alleviating the adverse impacts of stress and fostering overall well-being among nurses (Yu & Zhi, 2023). While the current study sheds light on the self-care practices employed by these healthcare professionals, it primarily provides a snapshot of their behaviors and preferences.

To gain a more profound understanding of the true impact of these self-care practices, longitudinal studies are warranted. These types of studies would involve tracking nurses' self-care behaviors over an extended period to assess how consistent engagement with these strategies influences their stress levels, job satisfaction, and overall physical and mental health. Longitudinal research would provide valuable insights into whether these self-care practices lead to sustained improvements in the well-being of nurses, helping to establish a cause-and-effect relationship between self-care and health outcomes (Chien-Lin & Zhi, 2023).

Furthermore, interventions aimed at enhancing self-care practices among nurses deserve attention. Implementing self-care education and support programs within healthcare institutions can serve as a practical way to provide nurses with the necessary tools and knowledge to engage in effective self-care. These programs could encompass stress management techniques, mindfulness practices, healthy lifestyle choices, and coping strategies tailored to the unique demands of the nursing profession.

By conducting research that includes longitudinal studies and interventions, researchers can accumulate more comprehensive and empirical evidence regarding the benefits of self-care practices for nurses (Price, 2020). This evidence would not only inform healthcare organizations about the importance of supporting their nursing staff in self-care but also contribute to the broader discourse on healthcare workforce well-being and the development of evidence-based strategies to mitigate the negative impacts of stress in the nursing profession. Ultimately, such research endeavors would help to create a healthier and more resilient nursing workforce, with positive implications for both nurses and the quality of patient care they deliver.

Conclusion

The present study provides insight into the self-care practices of Filipino nurses and highlights the importance of various forms of self-care in promoting their health and wellbeing. The findings suggest that physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual self-care are all crucial aspects of self-care for nurses. The study underscores the need for nurses to engage in self-care practices to cope with the demands of their profession and to provide quality patient care. The study also highlights the importance of social support, self-awareness, and seeking professional help as strategies for promoting nurse wellbeing. Further research is needed to develop effective self-care interventions and to promote self-care practices among nurses. Based on the findings of this study, it is recommended that healthcare organizations and nursing leaders prioritize the development and implementation of self-care programs and interventions for Filipino nurses. These programs should emphasize the importance of physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual self-care and provide resources and support to nurses to engage in these practices. Additionally, organizations should promote a culture of self-awareness, social support, and seeking professional help to ensure that nurses have the resources and tools they need to maintain their wellbeing. Further research is also needed to evaluate the effectiveness of self-care interventions for nurses and to identify best practices for promoting self-care practices among healthcare providers.

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